

STRIPED HYENA

Hyaena hyaena

Maligned in folklore as skulking, cowardly scavengers, most hyenas are also adept hunters in their own right. The striped hyena is less bold and sociable than its spotted cousin, and, in Africa at least, individuals tend to live a solitary life except when breeding. Elsewhere, such as in Israel and India, striped hyenas more often live in family groups, which are dominated by a single adult female. Carrion forms the bulk of the striped hyena's diet, but it is also partial to fruits, especially melons, which provide valuable water. Striped hyenas are unpopular with farmers, who fear attacks on livestock and damage to crops, but these animals increasingly need conservation, with perhaps fewer than 10,000 remaining in the wild.

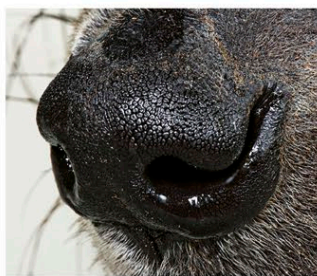
muscular shoulders and neck
allow the hyena to carry or drag
its own bodyweight in carrion

large ears follow
sound from any
direction



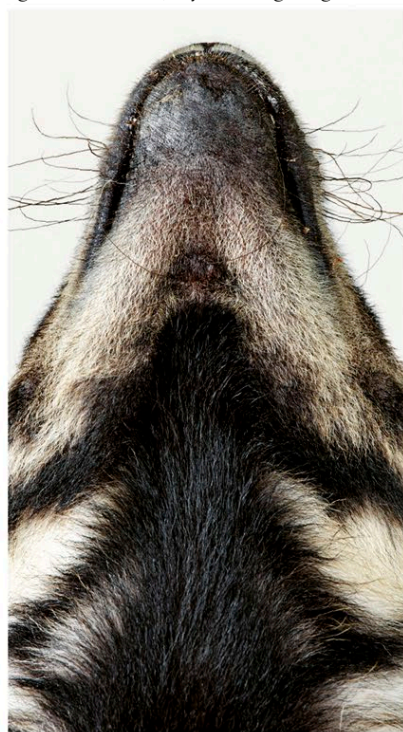
✓ THROAT

The black throat patch probably contributes to the animal's camouflage. The thicker hair in this area may provide some protection against serious injury when fighting.



^ NOSE FOR TROUBLE

Scent is an important sense to hyenas. Individuals often pause in their daily routine to daub scent from a gland under the tail on rocks and tussocks around their home range.

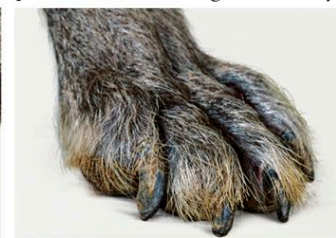
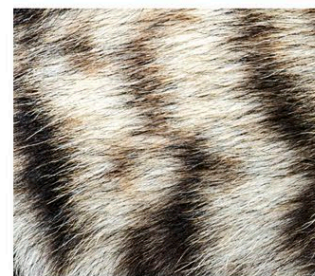


^ MOUTH AND TEETH

The hyena's stout jaws are operated by immensely powerful muscles. The large cheek teeth (molars and premolars) are easily capable of crushing bones.

< FUR

The striped hyena is smaller than the spotted or brown hyena, and is distinguished by black stripes on its legs and flanks. The pattern aids camouflage in its dusty habitat.



< ^ LEGS AND FEET

The front legs are longer than the back and terminate in compact paws with four digits on each. The claws are dog-like and are short, blunt, and nonretractile.

